PUNJAB

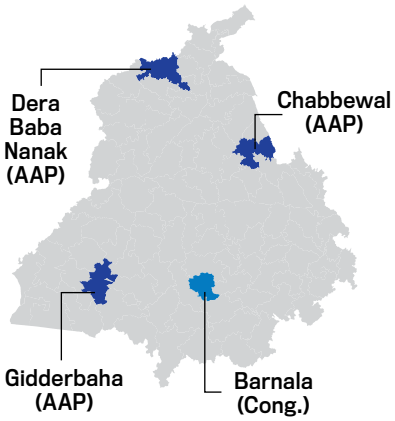
THE AAP SUPREMACY

Despite internal churn, the ruling party stays strong

Byelections in: **4 seats** | Won by: **AAP 3**; **Cong. 1**

A day before the results of the Punjab bypolls were declared, the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) announced significant changes in its state unit. Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann was relieved of his duties as state convenor, replaced by cabinet colleague Aman Arora, while MLA Amansher Singh Shery Kalsi took over as working president from CM loyalist Budh Ram. These changes, reflective of the central leadership's growing influence, did little to disrupt the party's grassroots grip.

AAP secured victories in three of the four constituencies: Dera Baba Nanak, Gidderbaha and Chabbewal, all previously won by the Congress. Notably, in Chabbewal, Ishank reclaimed the seat



his father, Raj Kumar Chabbewal, who had defected to AAP and now serves as Hoshiarpur MP, had vacated. The Congress suffered major setbacks, with stalwarts like Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa and state president Amrinder Singh Raja Warring failing to secure wins for their spouses in their strongholds.

But AAP's supremacy faced a setback in Barnala, where Gurdeep Bath, once Mann's confidant, contested as an Independent, splitting the vote and allowing the Congress's Kuldeep Singh Kala Dhillon secure a narrow win. Nevertheless, the bypoll outcome has injected fresh momentum into AAP following its disappointing performance in the Lok Sabha election, where it managed to win only three of the 13 seats. This time, AAP toned down Mann's visibility in the campaign, signalling a shift towards centralised control. Arora's elevation underscores this strategy.

Meanwhile, the BJP, banking on former Congress and Akali leaders, failed to make a mark, losing deposits in three constituencies. The Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) chose not to contest with its leader Sukhbir Badal embroiled in religious controversies, further consolidating *panthic* votes for AAP. The bypoll outcome in fact reinforces that AAP's churn is far from disruptive—if anything, it has solidified its foundation. ■

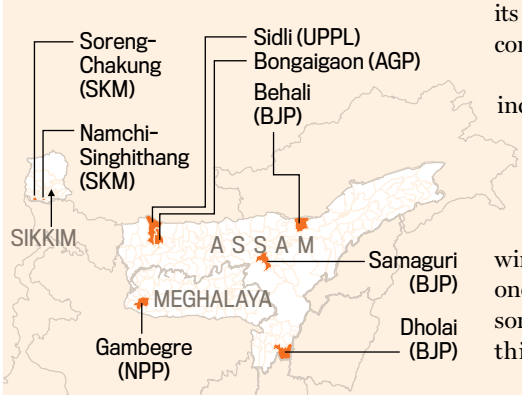
–Anilesh S. Mahajan

NORTHEAST

THE HOLD RETAINED

NDA reasserts dominance, sweeping all eight seats in three northeastern states

Byelections in: **Assam (5)**; **Meghalaya (1)**; **Sikkim (2)** | Won by: **NDA**



The National Democratic Alliance (NDA) reinforced its supremacy in the Northeast—after a hiccup in the Lok Sabha election—by sweeping the bypolls in Assam, Meghalaya and Sikkim. The BJP-led alliance has not only retained its six seats but also wrested two crucial constituencies from the Congress.

In Assam, the BJP won three seats, including the high-stakes Samaguri, a Congress stronghold held by former minister Rakibul Hussain since 2001. Earlier this year, Rakibul made his Lok Sabha debut, winning Dhubri by a record margin of one million-plus votes. But Rakibul's son Tanzil Hussain, contesting from this Muslim-majority seat, faced a stunning defeat to the BJP's relatively unknown Brahmin face Diplu Ranjan Sarma. Equally critical was Behali, where Assam chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma exacted political revenge against the Congress's Gaurav Gogoi—who had won the Jorhat Lok Sabha seat despite the BJP's well-oiled campaign.

In Meghalaya, the National People's Party (NPP), an NDA constituent, dealt a blow to the Congress by securing Gambegre, a seat it had never won before. The winner: Mehtab Chandee Sangma, wife of Chief Minister Conrad Sangma. In Sikkim, the ruling Sikkim Krantikari Morcha (SKM), also a BJP ally, won the two bypolls uncontested—thus keeping the assembly Opposition-*mukt*. ■

–Kaushik Deka